

Exclusive: Commission ignored own advice on CO2 standards

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【要点】

- ・ 欧州委員会が気候行動総局の内部助言者の警告を無視し、2025年1月に自動車メーカーのCO2排出基準の引き下げに反対する報告書を受け取った後、3月に基準を弱める自動車行動計画を発表した。
- ・ EUは2023年に2035年までに新車の排気ガス排出をゼロにすることを定めたが、自動車業界は規制見直しを2026年から2025年に前倒しするよう圧力をかけ、欧州委員会は12月に基準を緩和する提案をした。
- ・ 自動車業界と部品供給業者は、内燃機関が競争優位であり電気自動車の販売が不調であることを理由に規制緩和を求めており、欧州議会の交渉担当政党である欧州人民党はこれを支持している。
- ・ 気候行動総局の助言者たちは、自動車メーカーが過去の排出目標を達成しており新基準に対応した新モデルを投入していることを指摘し、2025年の中間目標達成によって彼らの見方が正しかったことが証明された。

【メール原文】

Navigating the complex world of EU mobility policy and infrastructure. By MARTINA SAPIO with JORDYN DAHL SNEAK PEEK — An internal document reveals the

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SNEAK PEEK

— An internal document reveals the European Commission ignored the recommendations of internal advisers before weakening emission standards for cars.

— The Commission unveils its new ERTMS deal today as part of an effort to speed its common rail signaling system.

— Europe's rail suppliers are pushing for deeper international partnerships to counter growing trade barriers.

Good morning, and welcome to Morning Mobility. Time to stop hogging the public charging stations. The Brussels region is implementing a rotation fee starting Oct. 1, with the goal of preventing users from leaving their EVs plugged in for hours.

Tips to jdahl@politico.eu , tlecca@politico.eu and msapio@politico.eu . Follow us @tommylecca , @jordyndahl and @martsapio .

DRIVING THE DAY

SCOOP: COMMISSION IGNORES ADVISERS ON CO2 STANDARDS: Although advisers for the Directorate General of Climate Action warned European Climate Commissioner Wopke Hoekstra against lowering emission standards for automakers in an internal briefing document, the European Commission put forward its Automotive Action Plan two months later that set the stage to do just that.

A matter of timing: The internal document, obtained by POLITICO, was submitted in January 2025 before a meeting between Hoekstra, the car lobby ACEA and the car parts suppliers' association CLEPA. The two organizations were lobbying to weaken the CO2 standards that acted as a de facto combustion engine ban starting in 2035.

Recap: The EU passed the ban in 2023, requiring a 100% reduction in tailpipe emissions from new cars by 2035. A review of the regulation was set for 2026, but automakers and their suppliers lobbied hard for the Commission to move the review to 2025. Commission President Ursula von der Leyen eventually presented her Automotive Action Plan in March 2025, and in December 2025, the Commission proposed watering down the EU ban .

Why it matters: The institutions are now negotiating whether the EU should further loosen the CO2 standards.

State of play: The sector argues that the combustion engine is their competitive advantage and sluggish electric vehicle sales make getting additional flexibilities even more crucial. The European People's Party, which campaigned on reversing the legislation and is the European Parliament's lead negotiator, is happy to oblige — submitting a draft report that goes further than industry demands.

Hold the line: DG CLIMA wasn't buying those arguments in 2025, arguing that automakers reached previous emission targets and were launching new models to meet the new standards. The advisers were proven correct with the 2025 interim target. EV sales surged 30% in 2025, growing to 1.88 million, ACEA data showed .

All about competitiveness: Rather than shielding the automakers and suppliers and giving them time to catch up, relaxing the emission standards would risk making Europe's industry less competitive, DG CLIMA argued in the briefing paper.

Read the full story from Jordyn here .

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rail

ERTMS DEAL LANDS WITH CAVEATS: The Commission unveils its new deal on the European Rail Traffic Management System today, as the EU remains well behind on rolling out its common rail signaling system. Brussels no longer expects to reach its 2030 targets.

The numbers: A senior Commission official told Martina national implementation plans indicate around 40,000 kilometers of ERTMS will be ready by 2030, compared with roughly 63,000 kilometers

previously envisaged — and even that lower figure may not be fully reached. Europe currently has around 12,000 kilometers equipped. “Perhaps if it’s not 2030, but it is perhaps 2035, [anyway] we’re moving ahead,” the official said, summing up the mood with: “The glass is filling.”

So what does today’s deal actually do? The Commission is trying to fix some of the structural reasons deployment has been so slow: too many tailor-made national solutions, poor coordination between infrastructure and trains, changing technical standards and patchy financing.

Policy alliteration: The official’ called for five Ss: standardization, synchronization, simplification, stabilization and scale-up. Standardization means using off-the-shelf solutions instead of bespoke engineering for every country or project. Synchronization means upgrading trackside infrastructure and onboard equipment together rather than leaving operators unable to use newly equipped lines. Simplification means cutting bureaucracy, not just speeding selected projects. Stabilization applies both to technical standards and to financing, so companies know the target and can invest in staff and production capacity.

But don’t expect an overnight fix: A central plank of the deal is the common technical blueprint we scooped last week , but that blueprint is not finalized. The official said its core elements are expected only around late 2027 or early 2028. Parts covering shunting yards and stations could come even later, around 2030. That makes the deal more of a medium-term reset than an immediate accelerator.

Why it took so long: The Commission’s diagnosis is that countries came to ERTMS for very different reasons. Some already had good national signaling systems and mainly saw interoperability as the benefit. Others were driven by safety concerns, while others simply had aging systems becoming impossible to maintain. For years, the EU also focused on interoperability while allowing national systems to remain in place. The official argued the real push only came in 2024, when Brussels made ERTMS the single European system and set deadlines for phasing out legacy Class B systems through 2030, 2040 and 2050.

And there’s now a security layer too: Brussels is also discussing how ERTMS fits with the military mobility package. The move toward future 5G/6G-based communications is also raising fresh cybersecurity questions. The official said current GSM-R systems are already vulnerable, but suggested the Commission sees workable solutions.

Bottom line: Today’s ERTMS Deal is less about declaring victory and more about admitting the old model has not delivered fast enough. Brussels is now trying to create the conditions for industrial-scale rollout — common designs, coordinated deployment, fewer administrative hurdles and more predictable money — in the hope that the EU can move from scattered projects to a single signaling system.

EU RAIL INDUSTRY LOOKS ABROAD: Europe’s rail suppliers are pushing for deeper international partnerships as trade tensions rise and access to foreign markets gets harder.

Who’s talking: UNIFE, the Brussels-based association representing Europe’s rail-supply industry, said on Friday that European companies can currently access only around 56% of the global rail market, even as demand continues to grow.

Open abroad, protected at home: The group held talks with delegations from the U.S., Canada, Saudi Arabia, India and Bangladesh at the InnoTrans convention in Berlin. It signed a memorandum of understanding with the American Public Transportation Association covering procurement, standards and high-speed rail. UNIFE has also been lobbying Brussels for stronger European preference clauses in public procurement, arguing that EU-funded rail investment should do more to support European

manufacturing.

Closer to home: UNIFE and rail operators' association CER also again called for a successor to Europe's Rail Joint Undertaking. The undertaking's Executive Director Giorgio Travaini told Martina that the next EU budget cycle will force a choice over which partnerships survive, and the rail sector will have to make the case for renewing the joint undertaking. Travaini said the Commission and member countries are considering what instruments they want in the next framework, while the Commission is also looking to reduce the overall number of partnerships.

His pitch: Travaini's argument is that rail remains one of Europe's strongest industrial sectors, and that continued EU-backed research is needed to keep that edge. He pointed in particular to the joint undertaking's system pillar work on standardizing signaling and control systems, saying the sector is now working toward common interfaces and the blueprint that could make ERTMS and related systems faster and cheaper to deploy. That work is due to run through 2028, and he said a renewed joint undertaking could then carry it forward.

INDUSTRIAL ACCELERATOR ACT

'MADE IN EUROPE' HAS LIMITS: A broad "Made in Europe" procurement scheme would do little to expand manufacturing inside the bloc and could just shift supply chains from China to other non-EU countries, our colleague Aude van den Hove writes after reading through a recent study from the European Parliament's industry committee .

In a nutshell: The authors weigh three ways of writing the origin rules, now debated in the Industrial Accelerator Act and a parallel rewrite of the EU's procurement rules. The tightest, limited to the 27 member countries of the bloc, gives the strongest reason to build in Europe, they say, though the gains for growth and jobs stay small. Opening it to trading partners makes the rules easier to game and leaves investors guessing.

Next up in Parliament: The three leading committees on the file — trade, industry and the internal market — are holding a joint debate on the IAA today, starting at 2:30 p.m. Expect the study to be brought up, along with more discussions about the role the trading partners will play in the Buy European scheme.

Tune in: You can watch it live here .

Headlines

Here's a recap of yesterday's news, along with Pro articles and alerts from overnight.

Britain to keep tariffs on Chinese EVs 'under review,' UK business chief says

Business Secretary Jonathan Reynolds said the U.K.'s position on the issue was "finely balanced" as officials pursue talks with Brussels.

By Graham Lanktree, Dan Bloom · Sept 27, 2026, 09:29 pm Europe/Brussels CEST

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